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Once an Athlete, Always an Athlete

Although I had retired from the track in 1964, I was still much in demand on the international circuit, and would be invited to attend events and meets all over the world. I was there in Munich for the 1972 Olympics and witnessed the tragic shooting of eleven members of the Israeli team, in what must be one of the dastardliest acts in the history of sports. With me in Munich was the celebrated American athlete, Jessie Owens, who had won three gold medals at the 1936 Berlin Olympics, where the world saw, for the first time, the power of Hitler's Nazi Germany. Both were events where the very essence of sportsmanship was overshadowed and diminished by politics.

In 1980, I was the only Indian sportsperson to be as chosen by the United Nations to carry a torch for peace throughout the world. Only the best runners from each country were given the privilege to participate in this humanitarian relay. I remember running along the Great Wall of China, and handing the torch over to the presidents of Nigeria and Kenya, as well as to Giani Zail Singh, who was then president of India.

When Delhi hosted the 1982 Asian Games, I had the honour of lighting the torch at the newly constructed Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium. After the ceremony was over, I was taken to the VIP enclosure and given a seat next to Rajiv Gandhi, his wife, Sonia, and her family. His mother and our prime minister, Indira Gandhi, was seated nearby.

We greeted each other cordially, and then Rajiv turned to his father- and brother-in-law and pointing at me, asked them, 'Do you recognize this